BUCKLE UP

TATA SONS EX-CHAIRMAN CYRUS MISTRY'S DEATH IN A CAR CRASH HAS PUT THE SPOTLIGHT ON THE IMPORTANCE OF SEAT BELTS FOR REAR PASSENGERS

Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS** *Text by* **M.G. ARUN**

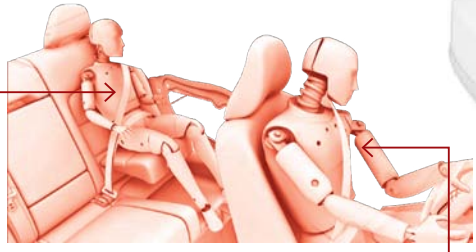
1.35
MILLION
Annual deaths in road accidents globally

25
PER CENT
Reduction in fatalities if rear seat occupants use seat belts

155,622
People killed in 403,166 accidents on Indian roads in 2021

WHAT THE LAW SAYS

The Centre has made it mandatory for automakers to provide three-point seat belts for all front-facing passengers in a car. Under Rule 138(3) of the Central Motor Vehicle Rules, a person "seated in the front seat" or "occupying front-facing rear seat" is required to wear a seat belt. Failure to do so may result in a fine of Rs 1,000. However, many ignore the rules for even front-seat passengers, not to speak of those sitting in the rear.



WHY YOU SHOULD WEAR SEAT BELTS

- When a car hits a moving or stationary object at a high speed, the passengers are thrown towards the front of the vehicle with a great velocity
- Passengers not seated upright and without seat belts can hit the seat in front of them, the side interiors, or even collide with fellow passengers
- According to the US-based Insurance Institute for Highway Safety, unbuckled backseat passengers are eight times more prone to serious injuries or death than those who do wear the seat belt



HOW IT HAPPENED

On September 4, Mistry and his friend, both seated in the rear, were killed and the couple in the front was seriously hurt after their speeding SUV hit a highway divider. Neither rear passenger was wearing a seat belt. Result: fatal head injuries.



WHY HEAD-ON COLLISIONS ARE SO DEADLY

What makes head-on collisions catastrophic is the sheer force generated by the impact. For instance, even at 20 miles per hour (about 32 kmph), and with seat belts on, the front row occupants would feel that they were hit by a mass of 1,500 kg. Without seat belts, the impact would be tantamount to being hit by a mass of 7,600 kg.